# COALITION

*Origin and concept report*

Concept by Ron Bronson
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COALITION began with an observation about the work required to leave a country under pressure. Even someone with money, influence, and powerful allies still depends on other people, institutions, and procedures. The reported escape of Flávio Bolsonaro prompted two connected ideas: a service blueprint of an escape and a game about navigating those dependencies.

## The article that prompted the idea

**How Bolsonaro Fled Brazil: Decoys, a Private Jet and a Friend in the White House**

The Wall Street Journal. Vera Bergengruen, Samantha Pearson, Ryan Dubé, and Philip Wegmann. Published October 28, 2026, at 9:00 p.m. ET. The October 29 print headline was “Bolsonaro’s Escape: Decoys, a Key Ally.” [1]

Read the original Wall Street Journal article

Read the WSJ article republished by To Vima

The article reports that Flávio Bolsonaro left Brazil after losing the presidential election, despite a court order barring departure and requiring him to surrender his passports. It describes a departure involving decoy vehicles and misleading reports about his location, followed by a journey south into Argentina. His family then traveled by chartered aircraft through Ecuador to Miami. [1]

The operation depended on several forms of assistance. Eduardo Bolsonaro and allies including Jason Miller helped arrange the charter. Argentine officials participated in receiving and moving the family, with a senior aide to President Javier Milei reportedly involved in coordination. In the United States, senior political figures supported the family’s entry. The article reports that the family ultimately entered under humanitarian parole allowing a one-year stay, after discussions about issuing visas. [1]

These details made the route more than a sequence of locations. Ground transport, cooperation in another jurisdiction, an aircraft and crew, refueling, and permission to remain at the destination all had to come together. The article also describes years of relationship building that preceded the immediate operation. [1]

The reporting does not fully explain how the Brazilian departure restriction was handled at the border. It also does not establish bribery. These remain limits of the account, separate from the design interpretation and the fictional game premise.

## The original observation

Ron’s interest was in the practical operation of bureaucracy and power. He focused on the effort required to negotiate relationships, move through institutions, and arrange an exit even when the person involved has substantial resources. The political identities of the people in the article were incidental to that inquiry. [2]

The southward journey was the detail that made the situation compelling. The reported operation required reaching another country and arranging onward travel from there. Ron was interested in the planning,

concealment, timing, and coordination involved in making that journey possible. He connected this to his interest in stories that show how bureaucracy actually works. [2]

His initial prompt named two subjects for further work: “the service blueprint of an escape” and “the game mechanics of this therein.” The first concerns how the operation functions. The second concerns what it might feel like to participate in such a situation as a player. [2]

## The initial response and service blueprint

The initial response identified the handoff as a useful unit of analysis: one person’s promise has to become something another person or organization can act on. This was an interpretation of the article, not a claim that the reporting documented every step. [3]

The response proposed examining physical movement, institutional decisions, and recognized status together. A completed journey involves more than arriving somewhere. Transport, entry, and permission to remain are distinct outcomes. An influential sponsor may help secure one part while other organizations remain responsible for the rest. [3]

### A compact record of the reported operation

The first two columns summarize the supplied article. The final column preserves the design interpretation from the original response. [1, 3]

| Part of the journey | Reported activity | Dependency identified in the response |
|---|---|---|
| Departure from Brazil | The family traveled and crossed into Argentina despite the departure restriction. The handling of that restriction was not fully described. | Physical movement and official restrictions can remain unresolved at the same time. |
| Reception in Argentina | Airport-security police escorted the family to airport processing. An Argentine aide reportedly coordinated with Eduardo Bolsonaro. | The journey brought a different government’s organizations and relationships into the operation. |
| Onward transport | A charter operator provided the aircraft and crew. The journey included a refueling stop in Ecuador. | Transport required commercial and operational support alongside political assistance. |
| Arrival in the United States | The family arrived in Miami and received the temporary permission to remain described in the article. | Political support for arrival took an administrative form; the journey and the continuing stay remained separate matters. |

### What the analysis made visible

Authority was distributed. A person able to secure political attention did not necessarily control transport, airport operations, or the receiving country’s procedures. The service blueprint made the connections among these contributions visible. [3]

Participants could also have different reasons for helping. A family member, political ally, commercial operator, and official might contribute to the same physical outcome for different reasons. The original response raised these as analytical possibilities; the article does not establish every participant's motives. [3]

Information moved at a different pace from the journey. The article describes reports that Bolsonaro had reached Florida while he was still in Brazil. The response distinguished the actual situation, institutional records, and what different people believed had happened. [1, 3]

Finally, the response noted that rules can continue to shape conduct even when someone breaches them or receives discretionary assistance. Following a procedure, obtaining an exception, violating a restriction, and encountering uneven enforcement are different circumstances. This observation explained the interest in bureaucracy without assuming that the whole journey followed an authorized process. [3]

## The original game idea

The initial game idea grew from the same observation: the player would encounter limits on what power, money, and influence can accomplish without other people's cooperation. Ron saw the escape as a source of suspense and potential play. His first prompt also contemplated other scenarios, including winning an election. [2]

Ron then named the game COALITION and explored a dice-and-card version. In that early discussion, dice would determine an election outcome. The majority would try to prevent an opposition figure from escaping, while opposition parties would help the targeted person leave. Cards would introduce routes and circumstances for the escape. The unequal benefit of that cooperation, and whether the majority would have a second player, were open questions in the conversation. [4]

### The later computer and phone direction

Ron subsequently narrowed the current computer and phone version to a single-player game. The player is the opposition figure who loses the election and must arrange their own exit. Computer-controlled characters, or NPCs, can help or obstruct the player. A canceled visa and a race against time create the immediate pressure. [4]

The player must determine who will receive them in another country, where they can go, and how to get there. The escape is the main experience. This returns the game to the service-blueprint question that prompted the original discussion: how the separate contributions needed for a journey are brought together under pressure. [4]

Ron wants the computer version to be replayable and suitable for phones. He mentioned a possible later board-game version in which players could choose sides, and an AAR-style record to preserve the development history for that purpose. The board-game possibility remained a future direction. [4]

The canceled visa belongs to the fictional game premise. The article describes a court order barring departure and requiring passport surrender. The historical account and the game premise are separate sources of detail. [1, 4]

## The original exchange

The original prompt is reproduced below. Selected passages from the first response preserve the analysis that connected the article to the service-blueprint idea. [2, 3]

### Original prompt

> this is a fascinating design case because it has nothing to do with the politics but that the reasn i lik shows about bureaucracy that demonstrate it is that even when you hve los of power, money and influence there are still rules like a board/video game that have to exist to navigate your ability to negotiate relationships ato ensure yo ucan say, escape across a border and get whisked away and surely there was bribes involved but nwhat's most interesting is it wasn't a wink and nod escape out of brazil despite the banm it's the leave the country south and get out that way that i find fasinating and cloak and dagger of having to do all the effort of people not finding you, lke this make me think of the premise of an actual game of some kind though you'd need more scenarios that including yu winning the election i'm thinking of two things -- the service blueprint of an escape -- and then separately the game mechanics of this therein

### Opening of the original response

> The most revealing unit here is the handoff: one person’s promise has to become something another person can act on. A powerful sponsor can agree to help, but someone still has to arrange transport, give instructions, recognize documents, process an arrival, and accept responsibility for what happens next.
>
> That gives you a strong design subject. Power has different uses in different places. Someone who can secure a president’s attention may have little direct control over the next operational step. Someone much further down an organization may control the decision that matters at that moment.
>
> It also explains why the southward journey is so compelling. As a design reading, the route shows movement through different arrangements of authority. Each boundary changes whose cooperation matters next.

### The service blueprint question in the original response

> I would map physical movement, institutional decisions, and recognized status together. A map of the journey alone would miss much of the work.
>
> The service outcome also needs a precise definition. In this case, I would use: the family reaches a destination and receives permission to remain there for a stated period. That keeps several accomplishments distinct: leaving, traveling, entering, staying, and establishing a life or political operation afterward.

## Sources


[1] Bergengruen, Vera; Pearson, Samantha; Dubé, Ryan; and Wegmann, Philip. “How Bolsonaro Fled Brazil: Decoys, a Private Jet and a Friend in the White House.” The Wall Street Journal, October 28, 2026, 9:00 p.m. ET. Article text supplied by Ron in this conversation; original publication link verified on October 29, 2026.

Original WSJ article | WSJ republication at To Vima

[2] Ron Bronson. Original prompt responding to the supplied article. Conversation, October 29, 2026. Reproduced in this report.

[3] ChatGPT. First response to the original prompt. Conversation, October 29, 2026. The report preserves its service-blueprint analysis and selected wording.

[4] Ron Bronson. Subsequent concept statements and clarifications in the same conversation, October 29, 2026, including the name COALITION and the single-player computer and phone direction.

Method reference cited in the original response: 18F Methods guide on service blueprints